

Party timeline template

Parties don't fail on the food. They sag in the middle because nothing was scheduled to happen. Fill in the times, print it, and hand a copy to one person who isn't you.

THE WEEK BEFORE

- ☐ **7 days out**
Confirm final head count with caterer or finalise the shopping list.
- ☐ **5 days out**
Confirm every vendor: arrival time, contact number, what they need from you.
- ☐ **4 days out**
Buy alcohol and non-perishables. Chill nothing yet.
- ☐ **3 days out**
Make anything freezable. Charge speakers, cameras, lights.
- ☐ **2 days out**
Clean, then set out furniture and tables. Test the playlist end to end.
- ☐ **1 day out**
Buy ice, fresh food and flowers. Chill drinks. Set the bar up.
- ☐ **Morning of**
Final food prep. Set out cups, napkins, bins, coats space, bathroom supplies.
- ☐ **2 hrs before**
Get yourself ready first. Everything after this belongs to the guests.

THE DAY — FILL IN YOUR TIMES

Vendors arrive Caterer, bartender, photographer	Setup complete Walk the room once, alone
Music on, doors open Never open to silence	Guests arrive Someone greets and takes coats
Drinks & canapés The first hour is drinks, not dinner	Food served The natural low point — feed them through it
Toast or speeches Short. Two people maximum	Cake
Music shifts up The moment the party turns	Photos / group shot Before anyone leaves or gets tired
Last drinks called	Guests leave Lights up, music down, coats out

TIMING THAT WORKS FOR A 4-5 HOUR PARTY

HOURL	WHAT'S HAPPENING	WHY
-0:30	Music on, bar ready, first drink poured	Early guests should never walk into silence
0:00-1:00	Arrivals, drinks, canapés	People need a drink in hand before they'll talk
1:00-2:00	Food served	Late enough that everyone's arrived, early enough to soak up the first round
2:00-2:20	Toast, then cake	Peak attendance. Any later and you're speaking to a half-empty room
2:20-4:00	Music up, dancing, the actual party	Everything before this was warm-up
4:00-4:30	Last drinks, slow the music, lights up slightly	Ending a party well is a skill. Signal it

ASSIGN THESE TO A HUMAN — NOT TO YOURSELF

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| ☐ Greeter
Welcomes people, takes coats, points at the bar. | ☐ Food runner
Refills platters, clears empties. |
| ☐ Bar keeper
Watches ice, mixers and glasses. Restocks before it runs out. | ☐ Photos
Someone whose job is to take them, or you will have none. |
| ☐ Music
One person owns the playlist and the volume. Not a committee. | ☐ Timekeeper
Holds this sheet and nudges you when it's toast o'clock. |

THE THINGS PEOPLE FORGET

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| ☐ More ice than you think
Drinks, coolers and the bar tub all eat it at once. | ☐ A quiet corner
Someone always needs one. |
| ☐ Somewhere for coats and bags | ☐ Taxi numbers or ride app ready |
| ☐ Bin bags and a plan for rubbish
Two bins beat one overflowing one. | ☐ Leftovers containers
So food goes home instead of in the bin. |
| ☐ Bathroom supplies
Spare roll, hand towel, bin. | ☐ Something for the next morning
Water and painkillers by the bed. You will thank yourself. |
| ☐ Phone chargers
Guests will ask. | |

The one rule: print this and give it to someone else. A timeline that lives only in the host's head isn't a timeline — it's a source of stress.

Using this with the HavenKept Milestone Birthday Planner: the times you fill in above go straight into the **Day-Of Schedule** section. Guest counts live in **Guest List**, the drinks and food in **Menu & Catering**, and the running order for music in **Playlist**. The role assignments on this sheet are yours to keep on paper — the planner tracks the schedule, not who's holding the clipboard.